Xi's increasing authoritarianism. The very fact that he and the leadership have chosen increasingly centralized and repressive means of rule suggests that they know something that we do not about China's prospects, and they are worried. The problem for the party leadership is: will authoritarianism in the long run make China more competitive or less able to compete? Will it stifle political dissent, or will it intensify it?

A broad conclusion about China's place in the world then is the following: it will continue to strengthen, but it will not be dominant. Its increasing centralization and authoritarianism betray worries among the leadership about its future. The US is likely to remain number one in comprehensive national power even if not in strict GDP terms. All the signs, though, are that it will be a troubled society. Its effective lead over China may therefore become quite narrow. A safe bet in other words is that the world will be bipolar, with two more or less equal Great Powers. The question is what role the US will play. If it retreats from Asia to focus on domestic challenges and security closer to home, then the continent could become a Chinese sphere of influence. In 2019, China's GDP was twice the size of India's and Japan's combined. If India does not grow its power rapidly, twenty-five years from now that ratio will be even bigger. If so, no coalition in Asia will be able to match Chinese power.

India's Challenge

The challenge for India in its dealings with China is clear enough. The persistently negative perceptions of each other's societies, the stubbornness of the border quarrel and suspicions over Tibet, and the questionable reliability of the US as a partner suggest that the power balance is the most dynamic element of the India–China relationship: it is the one thing that India can change by its own policies and choices. Diplomacy has helped stabilize the relationship between the two countries but only succeeded in producing what Jeff Smith in his perceptive book on India–China relations